

ROOTING FOR BANO Yami Gautam with Emraan Hashmi in a still from *Haq*

In

October 2025, Yami Gautam found herself part of some social media chatter she didn't expect. Film buffs felt she was wrongfully denied a popular award for her work in *Article 370* to favour an actress who had won the prize for a forgettable film that had failed at the box office. Yami heard the statements of support "loud and clear", but a few years ago she had already stopped "chasing anything" other than "great work". There was no bitterness about being overlooked for films like *Bala* and *A Thursday* and there was an acceptance of sorts. Says Yami, "It's absolutely OK not to seek any validation or to associate my success or standing in the industry [with whether] I am awarded or not. The fact that nothing is ever enough is one of the driving forces for me."

Anyone who has watched Yami in the recently released drama *Haq* will acknowledge that it is her best performance so far and indeed one of the standout female performances of 2025. Loosely inspired by the life of Shah Bano and the herculean legal battle she fought, one whose verdict would alter the socio-political fabric of India, *Haq* sees Yami essay Shazia Bano who files a case against her lawyer-husband (Emraan Hashmi) after he brings in a second wife and subsequently refuses to pay money for the upkeep of Bano's three children. He later also divorces her by pronouncing 'talaq' thrice. Yami commands the screen with her measured, convincing and low-on-histrionics act, one that has you rooting for Bano as she exposes patriarchy and misogyny while fighting for her dignity and rights. "Her anger stems from love—for her children and for her husband—and how inconceivable the betrayal was," says the actress. "You can feel the storm being held inside. The power always lies in resilience."

> A "FAN OF VERSATILITY", **YAMI GAUTAM** REFUSES TO BE BOXED INTO "ANY SET GENRE"

Directed by Suparn Verma and written by Reshu Nath, *Haq* steers clear of emotional outbursts or sensational dialogues to focus on a woman finding her voice. Rather than projecting her turmoil at a feverish pitch, Yami wanted to express it as an ordinary woman "who never imagined her life and that of her children could take such a drastic turn for years to come". Talking about her approach and the responsibility of playing a part like Bano, Yami says, "I wanted to make her universal.... Anyone who is watching it should feel a part of them being portrayed on screen. [As women] we have felt unheard and been conditioned to normalise certain things which are not right. She challenged within the periphery of her faith and without being disrespectful of it. She did something so impactful that it has been 40 years and she still stands relevant."

Yami's cinematic career so far is a story of two halves: pre and post *Uri: The Surgical Strike*, the film where she would meet her eventual husband, filmmaker Aditya Dhar. After making a strong first impression in Shoojit Sircar's delightful *Vicky Donor*,